

when we registered our marriage. And now when I was travelling recently, an air hostess was telling me how she is a Hindu, married to a Muslim in Dubai. I asked her, is that such a big deal? And she said, no, it was just something she wanted to share with me. Everyone knows I celebrate both Id and Diwali. Yet my wife has never celebrated either in a different or less way. The children do both Id namaz and Diwali puja and mix-and-match all the time with ease.

My only prayer to everyone is that if a nun is raped in Orissa, please don't make it a Christian versus Hindu issue, or if a blast takes place, don't say it is a Muslim versus Hindu matter. These are killers. Plain and simple. They have no religion.



And if they do have an agenda, I would like to say to them, go get another one. Go green, be good to poor people, educate a girl child, or even be kind to animals. I firmly believe that the country was heading towards a state of equality for all religions till a few people decided they didn't want it to happen. Yes, Hindus and Muslims have had historical problems since the Partition, so have Christians and Muslims since the Dark Ages.

But history is quickly forgotten. I believe modern young Indians need to feel that their work should be their religion and should define them. It will be a more neutral identity, have an international acceptance and will be based on their talent, their mind, and their heart.



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Delhi's blasts were in effect two sets of blasts: one that killed people and the other that tarnished the image of a community

I need to go back to the time I bought a house at Bhakti Park in central Mumbai. My wife found it difficult to live in a cosmopolitan environment because she wears a burqa. She is a graduate from KC College but prefers to follow religious practices while I am the opposite. I could have educated my neighbours or moved to a Muslim-majority area. I took the second, easier option.

Delhi's bomb blasts were in effect two sets of blasts—one that killed people and the other that tarnished the image of an entire community. The Indian Mujahideen e-mail will have far-reaching implications. For non-Muslim Indians, we shall be guilty of a crime we never committed. The real culprits, who may be Muslims, don't represent the majority of India's Muslims.

Muslims have, in the recent past, taken to education, but in this environment of suspicion, the youth will start to question the premise that education will change their lot. Even educated Indian Muslims will find it difficult to get jobs now. The common Muslim feels insecure, and this sense of fear is pushing more and more of them to community havens. Certainly some young minds are being used by fundamentalists. But since so many questions are being raised about the Batla House encounter, the Government should order a fast-track judicial probe. But to my disappointment, leaders like Sonia Gandhi and Dr Manmohan Singh have failed to provide social leadership to the country. There is a strong wave of discontent among minorities. We shall educate each and every Muslim to stop following their political masters who have cheated us for over 60 years. This is a fight for political liberty of Muslims. We want our share in governance so that if the vote-conscious leaders of the country fail to reassure the second-largest majority of the country, then we are able to assure them on our own strength.